

We Never Agreed

The case for an internet that belongs to the people who use it

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Most of us have made a quiet peace with the internet. We know, somewhere, that the feed is built to keep us scrolling; that the “free” service is paid for with our attention and our data; that the companies we depend on answer to their shareholders, not to us. We know it, and every day we click *I agree* anyway — not because we agree, but because there is no other button, and it all seems to be simply how things are.

But no one chose this — we only clicked *agree*. Every part of the internet we touch was built by someone, for a purpose, and the purpose was rarely us. The bottomless feed, the data taken without asking, the rules written in private and changed at will — none of it is a law of nature. It was chosen, because it paid a few people very well. And what was chosen can be chosen differently.

What follows is an argument that we should, and that, for the first time in a long while, we actually can.

The shadow you cast

Begin with what you make. Every day, you leave a trail: the things you search and buy and watch, the messages you send, the places you go, the people you know, the moods you let slip at one in the morning. Call it your digital shadow. It is not you, but it could not exist without you. It is cast by a single real life, yours, and no one else’s.

That shadow turns out to be worth a great deal. It is what lets a company predict what you will click, what you will buy, what you can be persuaded of, what you can be sold. Gathered across billions of people, these shadows are the raw material of some of the most valuable enterprises in history. And lately they have become something more than an advertising tool. They are the fuel of artificial intelligence — systems trained on the collected output of humanity that are beginning to reshape how nearly everything is made and done. The wealth of that intelligence is flowing, overwhelmingly, to the few companies that happen to hold the data.¹ Not because those companies are wiser than the rest of us. Because they hold the shadows.

That is the quiet bargain at the heart of the modern internet: you produce the value, and someone else keeps it. We the Users have quietly become *we the used* — a bargain never struck, only assumed.

Nothing natural about it

We have been taught to treat this as a kind of natural law — as though it were always bound to be the case that a few enormous firms would own the public square, the marketplace, and the running record of our lives. It is worth recalling how new this is, and how thoroughly it was chosen.

The internet did not begin as a machine for watching people. It began, not so long ago, as something closer to a commons — a place its early builders hoped would be open, decentralized, and free.² The surveillance, the consolidation, the sense that five or six companies simply *are* the internet now: these arrived later, and they arrived because someone decided that the surest way to make money was to harvest attention and sell prediction. It was a reasonable decision, given the incentives. It was still a decision. The engineers who built the feed to hold you could have built it to serve you. The businesses that kept the value could have been arranged to share it. None of this was handed down by nature. All of it was authored, and what is authored can be rewritten.

We know rewriting is possible, because pieces of the alternative already exist. Much of the internet's own foundation runs on software built by communities and owned by no one — given away, maintained in the open, relied upon by everyone. Wikipedia, written by strangers for free, outlasted the encyclopedias that were sold. And beyond software, the longer human story is largely the story of people taking power that looked permanent — that called itself natural — and making it answer to them. The means to own things together, to share what a network earns among the people who actually make it, are more available now than they have ever been. What has been missing is not the tools. It is the decision to use them.

What is yours

So let us say plainly what a fairer internet would look like.

Your data would be yours — held by you, not extracted from you. You would decide who may read it, write to it, and share it, and you would be free to take it and leave. The value the network created would flow back to the people who created it — not as a kindness handed down, but as a matter of ownership, the way a return belongs to an owner. The people who built and ran the thing would be paid, and paid well, but no founder, no engineer, and no investor would be set permanently above everyone else, drawing rent on a public square forever. And the rules of that square would be written in the open, by the people who have to live under them.

This is not a dream of an internet without companies, or without builders rewarded for building. It is the more modest and more radical idea that the rewards should not all collect at the top and stay there — that the people we still call “users,” as though they were merely consuming something, should be recognized as what they actually are: the owners of the value they create.

“But it cannot be changed”

The honest objection to all of this is not that it would be bad. It is that it cannot be done

— that the incumbents are too large, their advantages too entrenched, and the rest of us too scattered to do anything but accept the terms we are given.

That objection is serious, and it deserves a straight answer instead of a slogan.

Here is the straight answer. It will be hard, and there is no shortcut. A new network is least useful at the very moment it is smallest, when there is almost no one there yet, and becomes worth joining only once many people already have. There is no way to wave that problem off, and anyone who tells you otherwise is selling something. So we will not pretend that a finished, better internet is sitting on a shelf, waiting for you to switch to it. It does not yet exist. It has to be built, and it has to be built by the people who want it.

That is, in fact, how every founding works. The American Patriots did not wait until they had an army and a treasury to declare what they believed; they declared it first, and then they built what the declaration demanded. We are going in that order on purpose. The better tools, the shared rewards, the intelligence that belongs to the people it was trained on — those come *after* people gather, not before. A document like this one is not the finished country. It is the gathering.

And what makes this a moment rather than merely a wish is timing. The terms of the next internet are being set right now, as artificial intelligence reorganizes the whole digital economy and, with it, the question of who owns what. The settlement that hardens over the next few years could hold for a generation. It can harden in favor of the few who already hold our data, or it can be built, deliberately and in the open, for the rest of us. That window is still open. It will not stay open for long.

What we can do now

On the second of July, 2026 — two hundred and fifty years after a smaller group of people decided they would no longer be governed without their consent — we will publish a Declaration of Internet Independence. It makes no pretense of having already built the new thing. It says, plainly, that the internet should belong to the people who use it, that we intend to build it, and that we are inviting framers to write its constitution out in the open, where everyone can see.

You do not have to be an engineer, or an expert, or anyone in particular to be part of this. You only have to decide that the way things are was never really chosen — that it was built, and can be built differently — and to put your name beside the others who mean to build it.

That is how every founding has ever begun: not with a finished nation, but with a single sentence that enough people were willing to sign.

No one chose this. Let us build something better.

SOURCES & NOTES

1. Because data is *nonrival*, usable by many at once, the value built on it tends to accrue to whoever holds it, not to whoever generated it. Charles I. Jones and Christopher Tonetti, “Nonrivalry and the Economics of Data,” *American Economic Review* 110, no. 9 (2020); and, on returning that value to its source, Jaron Lanier, *Who Owns the Future?*

(Simon & Schuster, 2013). ↩

2. The early internet's promise of an open, self-governing commons was captured most famously in John Perry Barlow, "A Declaration of the Independence of Cyberspace" (Electronic Frontier Foundation, 1996) — a document this project admires but parts from, since declaring independence proved nowhere near enough to keep the network free. <https://www.eff.org/cyberspace-independence> ↩